DEQUAD

Business Plan — UK Innovator Founder Endorsement

Submitted to UK Endorsing Services (UKES)

Company	DEQUAD Ltd — Company No. 17405964, incorporated in England & Wales on 18 August 2026
Founder (sole)	Yusuf Quadri — Founder & Chief Executive Officer (lead applicant)
Wider founding team	Dr Gerald Marfo (CMO) · Adedapo Ajuwon (Senior Software Engineer) · Chinyere Jennifer (Senior Advisor, Programme Delivery)
Base	London — NatWest Accelerator (London hub)
Product	**Live and fully functional** on the **Apple App Store** and **Google Play Store**, and on the web at **dequad.co.uk**
Funding	£3,000 founder's capital now; £11,000 further equity (£3,000 friends & family, £8,000 Nigerian company) on a successful pilot and signed letter of intent — £14,000 in total
Financial year	1 September – 31 August (aligned to the UK academic year). Year 1 = FY27 (Sep 2026 – Aug 2027)
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1. Executive Summary

The business in one sentence

DEQUAD is a UK software platform that connects university students with verified peers, measures their wellbeing day by day, and gives their university an early, privacy-safe warning when a student or a cohort is heading towards crisis. Students use it for free; universities pay for it.

The problem

Loneliness and poor mental health are among the biggest reasons UK students under-perform or drop out, and universities have very few tools that detect either early.

- More than one in four higher-education students in England (**26%**) reported feeling lonely "often or always" — over three times the rate for adults generally (8%) (ONS, Student Covid Insights Survey, 2021). Nearly one in four (**23%**) report feeling lonely "all" or "most" of the time even after the pandemic (Advance HE / HEPI Student Academic Experience Survey, 2022).
- University support services are reactive. They find out about a student in difficulty when the student asks for help, or when something has already gone wrong.
- Students who look for connection outside university-run services use open social apps or unmoderated group chats. These are not identity-verified, have no safeguarding, and are invisible to the university.

The solution

DEQUAD closes a loop that no other UK product closes:

> **verified student identity → genuine peer connection → daily wellbeing signal → graded safeguarding alert → institutional action**

A student signs up with a UK university (`.ac.uk`) email address, is verified, and meets other verified students by shared interests. A 30-second daily mood check-in builds a personal wellbeing trend. When the platform detects warning signs, such as a run of very low mood, crisis language in chat, or falling engagement, it raises a graded alert to a trained human reviewer and, where the student's university is a partner, to that university's safeguarding team. Universities get an anonymised cohort dashboard and an AI-written wellbeing analysis that tells non-specialist staff, in plain English, where to act.

Why this team

The lead founder, **Yusuf Quadri**, is a practising safeguarding professional. He is a Recovery Coordinator at Change Grow Live, where he makes safeguarding referrals and dynamic risk assessments every week. He is also a Clinical Support Worker at East London NHS Foundation Trust. He served **two terms as President of the University of Bedfordshire Students' Union (2021–23)**, representing more than 10,000 students and overseeing a £900,000 budget. DEQUAD's escalation design comes from a practitioner, not a textbook. He is DEQUAD's sole founder. Three senior specialists support him on equity-only terms: a PhD digital marketer (CMO), a senior full-stack engineer who leads day-to-day engineering, and a senior programme-delivery consultant.

Where the business is today (October 2026)

Evidence	Status
Product	**Live and fully functional on the Apple App Store and Google Play Store**, and on the web at dequad.co.uk. Anyone with a UK university email can download it today. The live product includes verified matching, chat, daily mood tracking, lecture feedback, graded safeguarding alerts, admin verification queue, university dashboard, AI cohort analysis, CSV exports, Stripe and in-app billing, and partner-university licence management.
Company	DEQUAD Ltd incorporated 18 August 2026; sole founder and director Yusuf Quadri. £3,000 founder's capital in place. A further £11,000 of equity (£3,000 friends and family; £8,000 from a Nigerian company) is agreed **subject to a successful pilot and a signed letter of intent**.
Third-party validation	Santander Universities Pre-Incubator (completed 2025); NatWest Accelerator, London (joined 16 March 2026).
Users	Closed beta with verified University of Bedfordshire students.
Commercial pipeline	**Conversations with the University of Bedfordshire about a pilot are ongoing.** No pilot agreement is signed yet. The base case assumes no institutional revenue at all in Year 1.

The financial plan at a glance

The plan is funded by **£14,000 of equity** in two stages. The founder's £3,000 funds the business up to and through the pilot. A further £11,000 (£3,000 from friends and family and £8,000 from a strategic investor, a Nigerian company) is released once the pilot succeeds and the university signs a letter of intent, modelled for April 2027. Together with the in-kind support of the NatWest Accelerator and revenue earned along the way, this funds every month of the forecast. No loans, grants, tax credits or further investment are assumed. Cash stays positive in every one of the 36 months. The lowest month-end balance is £823 (Mar-27).

Base case	Year 1 (FY27)	Year 2 (FY28)	Year 3 (FY29)
Total revenue	£569	£22,111	£54,308
Gross margin	n/a	87.9%	89.3%
Profit / (loss) after tax	(£4,803)	£8,111	(£420)
Closing cash	£8,680	£18,526	£23,230
Paying partner universities (year end)	0	1	3
Insights Starter subscriptions (year end)	2	6	11
Verified students on platform (year end)	320	1,820	5,820
Team headcount / FTE (year end)	1 / 1.00 (founder unpaid)	1 / 1.00 (founder unpaid)	3 / 1.75

The base case is deliberately cautious: one paying university in Year 2 and three by the end of Year 3. That is about 1% of UK higher-education providers. A **growth case** (Section 10.5), also fully reconciled, shows what happens if seven universities and one NHS Integrated Care Board sign by the end of Year 3. In that case DEQUAD creates **four full-time UK jobs (a £30,000 Software Engineer and three roles at £25,000) plus a part-time safeguarding role**, pays the founder, and still ends Year 3 with £21,064 in the bank.

2. Products and Services

2.1 The platform

DEQUAD is live and fully functional on the **Apple App Store** (iOS) and **Google Play Store** (Android), and on the web at dequad.co.uk. All three run from a single codebase (Expo / React Native), backed by a Python FastAPI service and MongoDB. Both app stores reviewed and approved it against their privacy, safety and in-app-purchase rules before publication. It is built from five modules.

Module	What it does	Why it matters
1. Verified access	Sign-up is restricted to UK university email domains. A policy engine classifies each address: known student sub-domains are approved automatically, staff and alumni patterns are rejected, and ambiguous domains need a student attestation plus review in an admin verification queue. Email one-time-passcode verification and rate-limited login protect accounts.	Everyone a student meets is a real, verified UK student. Our own research says this is the single biggest reason students would trust a friendship app, and it is the foundation for any safeguarding that names an individual.
2. Connect (peer matching and chat)	Interest-based discovery across 60+ interests in 6 categories, with distance and preference filters, mutual-like matching, AI-suggested icebreakers and in-app chat. Report-a-profile, a hate-speech and profanity filter and crisis-keyword scanning run across bios, chat and support messages.	It addresses loneliness directly by helping students form friendships and study groups, inside a moderated, compliant space.
3. Wellbeing tracking	A 30-second daily mood check-in, with an evening push reminder, plus lecture feedback. Students see their own trends over time.	It turns wellbeing from a one-off survey into a continuous signal that can show deterioration early.
4. Safeguarding engine	Graded alerts: (a) crisis language detected in chat or support, (b) low-mood streaks (mood ≤ 3 for three or more consecutive days), (c) falling lecture engagement, routed anonymously for academic support. Every automated flag goes to human review. Students always see crisis routes (Samaritans, 999, university support).	It is a proactive safety net designed by a practising safeguarding professional, with a human always making the final decision.
5. University Insights	An anonymised cohort dashboard (mood trends, engagement, growth and retention KPIs), an AI-generated wellbeing analysis (score, key concerns, positive indicators, prioritised recommendations), per-university CSV exports, and licence management that unlocks full access for every student at a partner university.	It gives student-services teams evidence to act on and to report against their mental-health and harassment obligations, without exposing individual data.

2.2 How DEQUAD makes money

The business model is **freemium for students, paid for by institutions**. The pricing ladder below is already live in the product's billing code.

Tier	Customer	What they get	Price
DEQUAD Free	Any verified UK student	Connect: discovery, 3 likes a week, matching, chat, Likes You	Free
DEQUAD Premium	Individual students	Mood tracking, lecture feedback, discovery filters, unlimited likes	**£4.99/month** (Stripe on web; App Store and Google Play in-app)
Insights Starter	Students' unions, academic departments, colleges, smaller providers	Self-serve university dashboard, anonymised insights, safeguarding alert reporting	**£49.99/month**, card billing via Stripe, cancel any time
Partner-University Licence	Universities	Full Premium access for **every** student on the university's domain(s), university dashboard, AI cohort analysis, safeguarding alert routing to the university's team, CSV exports, onboarding and a named success contact	**£2.00 per enrolled student per year** (a 10,000-student university pays £20,000), invoiced annually in advance
NHS ICB partnership *(growth case only)*	Integrated Care Boards	Population-level, anonymised student wellbeing data and a joint referral pathway	From £20,000/year

Why this structure works. Students adopt DEQUAD because the social product is free and useful. The wellbeing features are what universities want their students to use, so a university licence "unlocks" them for its whole student body. That gives the university a reason to buy and DEQUAD a growing, verified user base to sell to. The Starter tier is a low-friction way in: a students' union or a single department can start for less than £600 a year on a credit card, then grow into a full licence.

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3. Innovation, Viability and Scalability

3.1 Innovation

DEQUAD is not a new feature added to an existing app. It is a new combination of capabilities that, as far as our competitor research shows (Section 6), no UK product currently offers together.

1. **Closed, verified student network.** Generic social apps are open by design and cannot add strict university-domain verification without breaking their own growth model. Peer-support incumbents are anonymous by design, so they cannot identify a student at risk. DEQUAD was built from the start around verified identity, with a domain policy engine, student attestation and a human verification queue.
2. **The integrated loop.** Connection data, daily mood and engagement signals are combined for the same verified individual, inside an institution that can act. Each piece exists somewhere in the market; the joined-up loop does not.
3. **Practitioner-designed, graded safeguarding.** Alert thresholds and routes reflect real safeguarding practice. Mood-based concerns go to welfare follow-up. Engagement-based concerns go

anonymously to academic support. Crisis language is escalated straight to human review. This separation, and the human-in-the-loop design, are deliberate safety choices.

4. **Decision support, not just dashboards.** A large-language-model layer reads multi-signal cohort data and returns a structured, plain-English analysis (a wellbeing score, the top concerns, positive indicators and prioritised actions) for staff who are not data analysts.
5. **Compliance built in from day one.** We drafted an Online Safety Act 2023 risk assessment, in-app reporting, a UK GDPR Data Protection Impact Assessment and per-institution data scoping before the first sale. This answers a major procurement objection before a buyer raises it.

Defensibility. A competitor could copy an email-domain check in weeks. It would be much harder to copy the safeguarding taxonomy, the human-review operating model, institutional trust and the longitudinal wellbeing data that builds up at each partner university. Over time, the verified network at each university also becomes more valuable to every student who joins it. Section 3.4 sets out the specific barriers to entry DEQUAD is building and how each one is protected.

3.2 Viability

- **The build risk is already retired.** DEQUAD is live and fully functional on the Apple App Store and Google Play Store, as well as the web. It has passed both stores' review processes, and billing, safeguarding and university tooling are all in production. Year 1 needs no development spend beyond hosting and tools.
- **The founder is the customer's peer.** University buyers are student-services and safeguarding professionals. The CEO does safeguarding work professionally and has led a students' union. He can talk to buyers in their own language, and he has existing relationships at the University of Bedfordshire, with whom pilot conversations are ongoing.
- **The cost base is very lean.** Year 1 cash costs are about £400 a month. NatWest Accelerator support (office, legal and accountancy, in kind until March 2027) and a founder who takes no pay in Years 1–2 mean the founder's £3,000 carries the business through the pilot, and the £11,000 released after the pilot is more than enough to reach the first institutional revenue.
- **Viability does not depend on a single deal.** Section 12.3 shows that even if the pilot fails, so that **neither a licence nor the £11,000 investment ever arrives**, the company stays solvent for all three years on Premium and Starter revenue in lean mode (Year 3 revenue £12,744; closing cash £8,570). Founder pay and the first hires are the things that would wait.
- **Willingness to pay is already proven.** UK universities already buy digital student-support services. Togetherall alone reports more than 200 education-institution partners, and UniBuddy has a large UK university client base. Universities have budgets for this kind of product; DEQUAD offers a more complete one.
- **The founder is committed, and others are backing him.** Yusuf Quadri has put £3,000 of his own money into the company and signed a commitment undertaking (Appendix C). Friends and family (£3,000) and a Nigerian company (£8,000) have agreed to invest once the pilot proves the product with a real university.

3.3 Scalability

- **Software economics.** An extra student costs DEQUAD pennies a month in hosting and AI inference. Gross margin rises to **89.3% in Year 3**. Revenue rises from £569 to £54,308 over three years in the base case, while the team grows by only two part-time roles.

- **A repeatable route into universities.** Each licence follows the same path: an unpaid pilot or Starter subscription, then a 6-week onboarding, then an annual licence. The licence-management tooling that adds a university's domains and unlocks every one of its students is already built. Adding a university is a configuration job, not an engineering project.
- **Network effects within each campus.** Every new verified student makes DEQUAD more useful to every other student at the same university. That drives organic sign-ups and lowers acquisition cost (Section 16).
- **National scale.** The UK has 2.9 million higher-education students (HESA 2023/24) at about 285 providers. The growth case needs only 7 of them to sign within three years.
- **International scale.** The verification engine is a configurable domain allow-list, not a rule hard-coded to `.ac.uk`. The same mechanism works for `.edu` (US), `.edu.au` (Australia) and European academic domains. We see international expansion as a post-Year-3 opportunity, not part of this forecast.
- **Job creation.** The base case grows from 1 unpaid founder to a paid team of 3 (1.75 FTE) by the end of Year 3. The growth case reaches **6 people**: the founder paid, a full-time Software Engineer, three full-time hires at £25,000 a year, and a part-time Safeguarding & Trust Lead. All of these roles are UK-based and funded from revenue.

3.4 Barriers to entry and intellectual property

A good idea in student wellbeing can be copied. DEQUAD's long-term defence therefore rests on four barriers: **protected algorithms**, **proprietary data**, **exclusive partnerships** and **registered IP** (patents and trademarks). The table separates what is already in place from what is planned, so each claim can be checked.

Barrier	In place today (October 2026)	Next step	Timing and cost
Protected algorithms (trade secrets)	The safeguarding logic runs **only on DEQUAD's servers**, never inside the app downloaded from the App Store or Google Play. That logic covers the graded-alert rules, low-mood-streak thresholds, crisis-language lexicon, risk scoring, cohort wellbeing score and the AI prompt designs. So it cannot be extracted by decompiling the app. Source code is held in a private repository with access limited to named team members.	Formal trade-secret register; confidentiality and **IP-assignment deeds** signed by every contributor (including the equity-only wider team), so all code and know-how is owned by DEQUAD Ltd; access logging and least-privilege access to production	Before the pilot (by Mar 2027), drafted under the NatWest Accelerator's in-kind legal support at no cash cost
Proprietary dataset	Every verified sign-up, daily mood check-in, match and engagement signal builds a **longitudinal, identity-verified wellbeing dataset** of UK students that no competitor holds. Anonymous peer-support platforms cannot build it, because they do not know who their users are. Generic social apps cannot build it, because they do not collect wellbeing data.	Licence terms giving DEQUAD the right to use **anonymised, aggregated** data to improve its models (never individual data, consistent with the DPIA at Appendix E); the personal-baseline model (Section 4.2) is trained on this data, so the product gets more accurate with every term	Data clause in the standard licence from the first contract (Oct 2027). Value grows each academic year: 5,820 verified students and three years of daily signals by the end of Year 3
Exclusive partnerships	Pilot conversations with the University of Bedfordshire are ongoing; strategic investment from a Nigerian company is agreed, conditional on the pilot	The **letter of intent** and first licence will ask for **preferred-supplier status for verified peer connection and wellbeing early warning** for the licence term. Partner universities would not run a competing product in that category while the licence is active. Each university's alert routing, safeguarding contacts and domain configuration also create switching costs once it is embedded in their safeguarding process	Sought in the LOI (target Apr 2027) and first licence (Oct 2027). Exclusivity is a negotiating aim, not an assumption: no revenue in the forecast depends on it
Patents	No patent has been filed yet. Software "as such" is excluded from patent protection in the UK, so DEQUAD will only file if a specialist confirms a technical contribution	**Patent search and patentability opinion** from a UK patent attorney on the most technical candidate: the method of combining verified-identity, mood-trajectory and engagement signals to produce graded, routed safeguarding alerts with per-institution data scoping. If the opinion is positive, a **UK priority application** at the UK IPO	Opinion in Year 2 (May 2028, £600); UK filing in Year 3 (Feb 2029, £1,500), both in the financial forecast (Section 13, legal & IP line)
Trademarks and copyright	Copyright in the code, designs and content belongs to DEQUAD Ltd	**UK trademark for "DEQUAD"** in classes 9 (software), 41 (education)	Filed once the post-pilot investment

Barrier	In place today (October 2026)	Next step	Timing and cost
	automatically; dequad.co.uk domain registered	and 45 (safeguarding / social services)	arrives (Apr 2027, £270, in the forecast)

Why these barriers stack. A competitor would need to copy all of them at once to catch up. That means rebuilding the safeguarding logic without access to it. It means waiting several academic years to collect a comparable verified dataset. And it means displacing DEQUAD at universities where it is already embedded in the safeguarding process, and possibly working around a patent. That is a far higher bar than copying an email-domain check.

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4. Research and Development

R&D is at the heart of DEQUAD's innovation. The two technical assets that make the product hard to copy, the **verification engine** and the **safeguarding inference pipeline**, are original engineering by the founding team. R&D in Years 1–2 is done by the founder and the equity-only engineering team without pay. No SME R&D tax relief is assumed in the forecasts; the company will review eligibility with its accountant once qualifying PAYE costs exist (from Year 3).

4.1 R&D completed to date

Work-stream	What was built	Status
Verification engine	UK student-email policy engine (approves known student sub-domains, rejects staff and alumni, flags ambiguous domains), student attestation, admin verification queue with audit trail, email one-time passcode, login lockout	**Live**
Safeguarding pipeline	Crisis-keyword and hate-speech filters across user-generated text; low-mood-streak detector; low-engagement alert channel; safeguarding alert dashboard with risk grading; alert-feedback loop that lets reviewers mark false positives	**Live**
AI cohort intelligence	Per-institution wellbeing analysis (structured LLM output: score, concerns, positive indicators, recommendations), streaming AI insight summaries, AI bio-writing help and icebreakers	**Live**
Entitlements and licensing	Freemium paywall; partner-university licences with domain matching (e.g. `beds.ac.uk` also covers `student.beds.ac.uk`), start and end dates, and enforcement at the API level	**Live** (built Sep–Oct 2026)
Security hardening	bcrypt password hashing, rate limiting, security headers, removal of personal data from API responses, chat safeguarding scanning	**Live**

4.2 R&D roadmap (funded from operating cash; founder time in Years 1–2)

Quarter	Objective	Measure of success
Y1 Q2–Q3	**Pilot-grade evaluation of alert precision.** Measure false-positive and false-negative rates of the low-mood and crisis-language detectors against human-reviewer decisions during the proposed pilot (method in Appendix D).	Reviewer agreement ≥ 80%; every high-risk flag reviewed within 1 hour in service hours
Y1 Q3	**Student-ID document check** with on-device redaction, for universities whose email domains cannot tell students from staff	Verification-queue manual workload down 50%
Y1 Q4	**Microsoft 365 / Azure AD sign-in** (most UK universities use it)	Single sign-on live for the first partner
Y2	**Personal baseline model.** Move from fixed thresholds to deviation from each student's own baseline (mood, sleep, engagement), reducing alerts for students whose "normal" is simply lower	False positives down ≥ 30% compared with fixed thresholds, with no fall in sensitivity
Y2	**Safeguarding webhook and adapter library** to send graded alerts into universities' own case-management systems	Integrated with the first two partners
Y3	**Privacy-preserving institutional analytics**: hash-based de-identification and minimum cohort sizes, so nobody can be re-identified from university reports	Independent DPIA review signed off

Governance. Every model output that affects a student goes to a human reviewer. The CEO owns the safeguarding policy. A clinical and safeguarding advisory panel will be formed in Year 2 (Section 9).

5. Market Analysis

5.1 Market definition

DEQUAD sells into the **UK higher-education student-wellbeing and engagement software** market. Its users are students, and its buyers are university student-services, wellbeing and safeguarding teams, and in time NHS Integrated Care Boards.

Indicator	Figure	Source
Students at UK higher-education providers	**2,904,425** (2023/24)	HESA, *Higher Education Student Statistics: UK 2023/24*
New entrants each year	~1.32 million	HESA 2023/24
UK higher-education providers	c.285 universities and HE colleges	HESA / Universities UK
Students feeling lonely "often or always"	26%, compared with 8% of all adults	ONS Student Covid Insights Survey, 2021
Students lonely "all or most of the time"	23%	Advance HE / HEPI Student Academic Experience Survey, 2022

5.2 Market size

Tier	Definition	Basis	Annual value
TAM	Every UK HE student covered by a licence at £2/year, plus a 1% Premium take-up among students not covered	2.9m × £2 + (1% × 2.9m × £59.88)	**c.£7.5m**
SAM	Universities with 10,000+ students (where a dedicated wellbeing platform is most likely to be bought): about 100 providers, about 2.0m students	2.0m × £2 + Premium share	**c.£5m**
SOM (Year 3, base case)	3 partner licences + 11 Starter subscriptions + Premium	Section 11	**£54,308** (c.1% of SAM)

The headline per-student price is deliberately low so that the buying decision sits within a Director of Student Services' delegated budget authority. The larger long-term prize is adjacent: NHS ICB data partnerships, further-education colleges, and English-speaking international markets with the same domain-based verification. None of these is in the base-case forecast.

5.3 Market drivers

1. **Policy pressure on student mental health.** The Department for Education has called on all universities to join the University Mental Health Charter Programme, and the Higher Education Mental Health Implementation Taskforce has pushed institutions towards earlier identification of students at risk and better data sharing. Universities are expected to show **prevention**, not just reaction.
2. **OfS condition E6 (harassment and sexual misconduct).** In force from 1 August 2025, it requires English providers to take steps to prevent and respond to harassment, including in online spaces they facilitate. DEQUAD's reporting, language filtering and audit trail help evidence this.
3. **Online Safety Act 2023.** Ofcom's illegal-harms and children's-safety duties are now being enforced. Informal student group chats and open apps leave universities exposed to unmanaged risk; a compliant, moderated, verified space reduces it.
4. **Budget constraint.** Universities are under financial pressure. Low-cost, per-student SaaS that reduces counselling demand and improves retention is easier to justify than more staff. Our price is set for this environment.

5.4 Customer research

The founder has run structured discovery with students and university staff since 2024, through the Santander Pre-Incubator and NatWest Accelerator programmes and the CEO's students'-union network. This included student interviews and a student survey, conversations with student-services and safeguarding staff, and the closed beta at the University of Bedfordshire. The research documents used for this plan are held in the DEQUAD evidence pack (Section 5.5) and are available to UKES on request. The research produced five findings that shaped the product:

1. **Trust is the barrier to connection.** Students want more friends at university, but they are wary of open apps. "Everyone is a verified student at a real UK university" was the strongest reason students gave for being willing to try a friendship app.
2. **Price sensitivity.** Students see about £5 a month as the ceiling for optional premium features. This set the £4.99 Premium price.

3. **University buyers ask about safeguarding first.** Staff asked "what happens when a student is at risk?" before asking about engagement. So safeguarding is the core product, not an add-on.
4. **Named-individual escalation is the gap.** Anonymous peer-support tools cannot let a university act on a specific student at risk. Verified identity, with student consent and a clear lawful basis, can.
5. **Small contracts move quickly.** Pilots and contracts below formal tender thresholds can usually be approved within student services. This is why the plan uses unpaid pilots and a low-cost Starter tier as the way in.

5.5 Research evidence pack

The research behind this plan is documented in the DEQUAD submission folder, which is provided alongside this plan:

Document	What it evidences
Wellbeing baseline and pilot evaluation methodology (Appendix D)	How wellbeing is measured and how the Bedfordshire pilot will be judged a success
Data Protection Impact Assessment (Appendix E)	Data-protection research, lawful basis and risk controls for mood data
Online Safety Act 2023 compliance statement (Appendix I)	Regulatory research and the platform's risk assessment
Architecture diagram (Appendix J) and product screenshots (Appendix K)	The live product and its technical design
Risk register (Appendix L)	Scored commercial, product, regulatory and team risks with mitigations
University letter of interest template (Appendix H)	The letter of intent to be signed after a successful pilot
Decision-maker brief, pitch deck and interview preparation sheet	Market sizing, competitor research and buyer positioning
Marketing research (`marketing/` folder: social captions, founder-story reel, ad concepts)	Student-facing messaging tested for the campus launch
Live product analytics (admin growth dashboard)	Sign-ups, active users, retention and mood-check completion from the beta

6. Competitor Analysis

We compared DEQUAD with six alternatives that UK students or universities use today. They fall into three groups: institutional peer support (Togetherall, TalkCampus), institutional engagement (UniBuddy), youth mental-health services (Kooth / Qwell), and consumer social tools (Bumble For Friends, Discord and WhatsApp groups).

6.1 Competitor profiles

#	Competitor	What it is	Business model	Strengths	Weaknesses compared with DEQUAD
1	**Togetherall**	Anonymous, clinically moderated online peer-support community with self-help courses	Institutional licence; reports 200+ education-institution partners	Strong clinical brand; 24/7 moderation; well-established with UK universities	Anonymous by design, so it cannot escalate a named student; no peer matching to build real-world friendships; no daily wellbeing telemetry
2	**TalkCampus**	Global peer-support app for students, with moderated conversations	Institutional licence	Large international student community; available 24/7	Not limited to verified students at one university; no institutional early-warning dashboard tied to verified identity; focused on support rather than connection
3	**UniBuddy**	Peer-to-peer chat platform used mainly for student recruitment and onboarding	Institutional SaaS licence	Large UK client base; proves universities buy student-engagement SaaS	Built for recruitment and transition, not for wellbeing; no mood tracking or safeguarding layer
4	**Kooth / Qwell**	Digital mental-health services with counselling and community	Commissioned by NHS and local authorities; some institutional contracts	Clinical services and practitioners; NHS commissioning relationships	A clinical service rather than prevention through peer connection; not built around a verified university network; higher cost to commission
5	**Bumble For Friends (BFF)**	Consumer friendship-matching app	Free plus paid tiers	Large user base; polished matching experience	Not student-verified; no university partnership; no wellbeing or safeguarding; generates no institutional value
6	**Discord / WhatsApp / Instagram groups**	Informal student communities and group chats	Free	Students already use them; no friction	Unmoderated, unverified and invisible to the university; a growing Online Safety Act and E6 risk; no early warning

6.2 Feature and benefit comparison

Capability	DEQUAD	Togetherall	TalkCampus	UniBuddy	Kooth/Qwell	Bumble BFF	Discord/groups
Verified students only (university email)	✅	❌	❌	Partial	❌	❌	❌
Peer matching for real friendships	✅	❌	❌	Partial	❌	✅	Partial
Daily mood / wellbeing tracking	✅	Partial	Partial	❌	Partial	❌	❌
Graded safeguarding alerts with human review	✅	Partial (moderation)	Partial (moderation)	❌	✅ (clinical)	❌	❌
Alerts routed to the student's university	✅	❌	❌	❌	❌	❌	❌
Anonymised university cohort dashboard	✅	✅	Partial	✅ (engagement)	Partial	❌	❌
AI plain-English cohort analysis	✅	❌	❌	❌	❌	❌	❌
Free core product for students	✅	✅ (if licensed)	✅	✅	✅	✅	✅
Self-serve entry tier (under £600/year)	✅	❌	❌	❌	❌	n/a	n/a
Online Safety Act risk assessment and reporting	✅	✅	✅	✅	✅	✅	Partial

Comparison based on each competitor's public materials, reviewed October 2026. "Partial" means the capability exists in a limited or different form.

6.3 Where DEQUAD wins, and where it does not

- **DEQUAD wins** where a university wants **prevention**: students who are not yet asking for help, but whose isolation and falling mood can be seen early, inside a space the university can stand behind.
- **Togetherall and Kooth win** where a university needs **clinical** support and 24/7 moderated services. DEQUAD does not compete with them on clinical care. We position DEQUAD as complementary: our alerts and signposting send students towards the university's existing clinical and counselling partners.
- **Price.** At £2 per student, DEQUAD is designed to cost less per student than established institutional platforms. For a mid-sized university, the decision can sit within a Director of Student Services' budget authority.

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7. Staff Profile and Recruitment Strategy

7.1 Founder

Role	Name	Background	Responsibilities
Founder & CEO (sole founder and director)	**Yusuf Quadri**	Recovery Coordinator, Change Grow Live (safeguarding referrals, risk assessment, multi-agency work); Clinical Support Worker, East London NHS FT; 2× President, University of Bedfordshire SU (2021–23, 10,000+ students, £900k budget); MBA with Data Analytics; MSc and BSc in International Relations; seven safeguarding and clinical-awareness certifications (Appendix O); B2B business development experience; built and launched the DEQUAD product	Strategy, university sales and partnerships, the Bedfordshire pilot, safeguarding policy and review, product ownership, finance, compliance and investor relations

How the founder supports himself. Yusuf draws no salary in Years 1–2. He meets his living costs from existing professional income and savings until DEQUAD can pay him (from Year 3 in the base case). DEQUAD is his main business focus and the reason for this application. Founder pay is the first cost to grow as revenue grows (Section 18).

Technical leadership as a sole founder. Engineering is led day to day by Adedapo Ajuwon (Senior Software Engineer, below), with the founder as product owner. The codebase is documented, version-controlled and deployed through managed services (Expo EAS, MongoDB Atlas). This means no single person's knowledge is needed to keep it running. A paid Software Engineer role (0.5 FTE in the base case, full-time in the growth case) is the first technical hire in Year 3.

7.2 Wider founding team (equity-only)

Role	Name	Contribution
Chief Marketing Officer	**Dr Gerald Marfo** (PhD, Digital Marketing)	Brand, two-sided go-to-market, measurement framework (cost per sign-up, conversion), campus campaigns
Senior Software Engineer	**Adedapo Ajuwon**	Additional full-stack engineering capacity, code review and release quality
Senior Advisor, Programme Delivery	**Chinyere Jennifer** (Senior Project Management Consultant, MIGSO-PCUBED)	Pilot governance, implementation planning, university onboarding playbook

These team members hold EMI share options (4-year vesting, 1-year cliff). No salary is assumed for them in Years 1–2. Adedapo Ajuwon will be offered the paid Software Engineer role first when it opens in Year 3. CVs are at Appendix N.

7.3 Hiring plan

Role	Base case	Growth case	Salary	Funded by
Founder & CEO	Paid from Sep 2028	Paid from Sep 2028	£10,000 (base); £24,000 (growth)	Revenue
Software Engineer	Sep 2028, 0.5 FTE	Sep 2028, full-time	£12,500 (base, 0.5 FTE); £30,000 (growth)	Licence revenue
Safeguarding & Trust Lead (part-time, about 10 hours a week)	Sep 2028	Sep 2028	£8,000	Licence revenue
Sales Lead (full-time)	—	Sep 2028	£25,000	Licence revenue
Support Agent (full-time)	—	Oct 2028	£25,000	Licence revenue
Student Ambassador (full-time)	—	Oct 2028	£25,000	Licence revenue

Full job descriptions are at Appendix G. Every role is UK-based and paid through PAYE.

Hiring gate. The founder will only make a paid hire when cash at bank, plus licence income already contracted for the next 12 months, covers the new role's fully loaded cost for 12 months on top of all existing commitments. This is how the plan keeps job creation and cash safety in step.

7.4 Recruitment strategy

- **Channels.** Safeguarding roles: CharityJob, the AMOSSHE network, and NHS and charity networks. Sales and support: Otta, LinkedIn and the NatWest Accelerator alumni network. Student Ambassador: partner-university careers services and students'-union networks.
- **Safe recruitment.** Every role needs an enhanced DBS check, two references and DEQUAD's safeguarding induction, in line with Keeping Children Safe in Education and adult-safeguarding good practice. Some university users are under 18.

- **Fair process.** Every role is advertised openly for at least 14 days, with the salary published. CVs are shortlisted blind, and interviews are structured and scored.
- **Retention.** EMI options for all permanent staff, flexible and hybrid working, and protected time for training and reflective supervision for safeguarding staff.

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8. Marketing and Sales Strategy

8.1 Positioning

> **"The verified student network that helps universities see loneliness early, before it becomes a crisis."**

Audience	Core message	Proof point
Students	"Meet real students at your uni. Verified, safe, free."	`.ac.uk` verification; free Connect
Universities	"See wellbeing risk early. Act on evidence, not guesswork."	Graded alerts, AI cohort analysis, dashboard
Students' unions and departments	"Start this week for £49.99 a month."	Self-serve Starter tier

8.2 Go-to-market: "land, prove, expand"

Stage	What happens	Target timing (base case)
1. Land (students)	Ambassador-led launch at the University of Bedfordshire; freshers' and January welcome-week activity; social content made by students	Sep 2026 onwards
2. Land (institution)	Unpaid 12-week pilot with the University of Bedfordshire (conversations ongoing), plus Starter subscriptions sold to students' unions and departments	Pilot targeted for Jan–Mar 2027 (**not yet signed**); first Starter subscription Apr 2027
3. Prove	Pilot readout: sign-ups, active use, mood-check completion, alert precision and staff feedback (method in Appendix D)	Apr–May 2027
4. Convert	Annual licence for academic year 2027/28, invoiced in advance	First licence term from Oct 2027 (contingent)
5. Expand	Case study and referral used to win further universities; Starter customers upgraded to licences	2 further licences in Year 3 (Sep 2028 and Mar 2029)

8.3 Student acquisition

- **Student ambassadors.** Paid in referral rewards and vouchers; one per campus.
- **Campus moments.** Freshers' and January welcome weeks, society fairs and SU events. Sign-ups follow the academic calendar: about 30% fall in Sep–Oct and about 12% in January (see Section 11.1).

- **App-store presence.** DEQUAD is live on the Apple App Store and Google Play, so every campus campaign sends students straight to a one-tap download. App-store optimisation (keywords such as "uni friends" and "student wellbeing", screenshots and ratings prompts after a first match) is a free, always-on acquisition channel.
- **In-product virality.** Free Connect, mutual-match notifications and invite links. Each new verified student makes the network more useful to everyone else at the same university.
- **Content.** Instagram and TikTok content made by and for students; search-optimised guides on making friends at university.

8.4 Institutional sales

- **Founder-led selling** in Years 1–2, using the CEO's safeguarding credibility and students'-union network, and introductions from the NatWest Accelerator.
- **Sector presence.** AMOSSHE (the student-services organisation) events, Universities UK and Wonkhe events, and a DEQUAD safeguarding white paper.
- **Sales assets.** Pilot evaluation report, DPIA pack, OSA statement, security summary (Cyber Essentials from Year 1) and a standard licence agreement reviewed by solicitors.
- **Sales-cycle assumption.** 3–6 months from first meeting to contract for sub-threshold contracts, aligned to academic-year budgets.

8.5 Sales and marketing KPIs

KPI	Y1 target	Y2 target	Y3 target
Verified students (year end)	320	1,820	5,820
Premium subscribers (year end)	5	20	59
Insights Starter subscriptions (year end)	2	6	11
Partner-university licences (year end)	0	1	3
Students covered by licences	0	10,000	26,000

9. SWOT Analysis

Strengths	**Weaknesses**
Fully functional product live on the Apple App Store, Google Play and web, so build and distribution risk is retired	Small funding base (£14,000) for a two-sided market
A CEO who practises safeguarding and has led a students' union: strong credibility with buyers	Bedfordshire pilot still under discussion; no signed pilot, letter of intent or paying institution yet
A distinctive integrated loop: verification, connection, wellbeing, safeguarding	Sole founder: key-person risk until Year 3 hires, mitigated by the equity-only wider team
Server-side protected algorithms and a growing verified wellbeing dataset (Section 3.4)	No patent filed or exclusivity agreed yet: both are planned (Section 3.4), not in place
Freemium model with a self-serve paid entry tier, already live in billing	Founder is unpaid in Years 1–2 and has other professional commitments
Lean cost base; NatWest in-kind support until March 2027	No clinical advisory panel yet (planned for Year 2)
Compliance work done before sale (OSA risk assessment, DPIA)	Limited brand awareness outside Bedfordshire
Opportunities	**Threats**
Policy pressure on prevention (Mental Health Charter, Taskforce, OfS E6)	Incumbents (Togetherall, TalkCampus, UniBuddy) add verification or matching
2.9m students and c.285 providers; low price fits tight budgets	University budget cuts delay purchasing decisions
NHS ICB partnerships for population-level student data	A mishandled safeguarding incident damages trust
Further-education colleges and international `.edu` markets	Cost-of-living pressure lowers Premium take-up
SME R&D tax relief once qualifying costs exist	Changes to AI-provider pricing or regulation

9.1 How we respond to the main risks

Risk	Mitigation
No pilot or licence converts	The plan stays solvent without any licence (Section 12.3); Starter and Premium give revenue from other sources; the pipeline is widened to other universities through the NatWest and SU networks from Year 1 Q3
Safeguarding incident	Human review of every high-risk flag; crisis routes always visible in the app; incident playbook written by the CEO; professional indemnity and cyber insurance from Month 1; clinical advisory panel in Year 2
Data breach	Data minimised and identity separated from mood data; encryption; Cyber Essentials in Year 1; DPIA reviewed annually
Competitive copying	Barriers in Section 3.4: server-side trade secrets and IP-assignment deeds, a growing proprietary verified dataset, preferred-supplier terms sought in the LOI and licences, a patentability opinion and possible UK filing, and a UK trademark; plus positioning DEQUAD as complementary to clinical incumbents
Founder capacity (sole founder)	Founder pay starts in Year 3; the wider team covers engineering, marketing and delivery; the Year 3 hires take over engineering and safeguarding review; documented operating procedures and managed infrastructure reduce dependence on one person

The full scored risk register is at Appendix L.

10. Investment Strategy and Funding Requirement

10.1 Funding requirement

DEQUAD needs **£14,000** to deliver this plan. It has three sources:

Source	Amount	Form	Timing (as modelled)
Founder's capital (Yusuf Quadri)	£3,000	Ordinary shares	In place at the start of Year 1 (Sep 2026)
Friends and family	£3,000	Ordinary shares	**Conditional:** on a successful pilot and signed LOI (modelled April 2027)
Strategic investor: Nigerian company	£8,000	Ordinary shares	**Conditional:** on a successful pilot and signed LOI (modelled April 2027)
Total cash funding	**£14,000**		
NatWest Accelerator in-kind support (office space, legal, accountancy, mentoring)	Non-cash		Active until March 2027

All three investments are equity. There is no debt to repay and no interest to pay. Shares for each investor will be issued and filed with Companies House (form SH01) when the money is received. The founder will keep a majority of the company.

The investment trigger. Both outside investors have made their investment conditional on two things: (1) a successful pilot with the University of Bedfordshire, judged against the success measures in Appendix

D; and (2) the university signing a letter of intent to take a paid licence (template at Appendix H). Pilot conversations are ongoing, so the plan models the pilot for January–March 2027 and the investment for April 2027. Until then, the business runs on the founder's £3,000 (Section 12.2). If the pilot does not lead to a letter of intent, the investment does not arrive. Section 12.3 shows what the founder does in that case. Evidence of each investor's identity and source of funds, including the Nigerian company's registration, the board resolution approving the investment and the bank transfer record, will be held on file and is available to UKES.

Why a Nigerian strategic investor matters. As well as cash, the investment is an early commercial link to one of Africa's largest higher-education markets. That supports the international scalability case in Section 3.3. Any expansion into that market is a post-Year-3 opportunity and is not in the forecast.

10.2 Use of funds

Use	Year 1	Funded by
Before the pilot decision (Sep 2026 – Mar 2027): platform running costs, insurance, ICO registration, developer accounts, the Bedfordshire pilot (£300) and minimal organic marketing	c. £2,500	Founder's capital
After the LOI (Apr – Aug 2027): student acquisition and pre-arrival campaign for the 2027 freshers' season	c. £1,100	Friends & family
UK trademark (3 classes), Cyber Essentials certification and QA test devices, all needed for institutional sales	c. £1,250	Friends & family / Nigerian company
Platform and overhead running costs, Apr – Aug 2027	c. £1,400	Nigerian company
Working-capital reserve carried into Year 2 (freshers' season and first licence onboarding)	£8,680	Nigerian company

Year 1 net trading cash outflow is £5,320. The company ends Year 1 with £8,680 in the bank. From Year 2, licence fees invoiced annually in advance turn cash flow positive. The pre-pilot period is deliberately lean, and spending on institutional-sales items (trademark, Cyber Essentials, devices) waits until the letter of intent is signed.

10.3 Why the round is small

The founder has deliberately raised only what the plan needs, and has tied it to proof. Raising a large equity round before a university has paid would mean giving away a large share of the company at a low valuation. The disciplined route is to prove conversion with one paying university first, which makes DEQUAD investable on much better terms.

10.4 Future investment (optional, not assumed)

When the first licence has renewed and at least three universities are paying (base case: during Year 3), the founder may raise a **pre-seed round of about £250,000**, for example under SEIS/EIS. The purpose would be to speed up the hiring in the growth case and expand to further-education and international markets. This is an option, not a requirement. None of the forecasts in this plan include it.

10.5 Growth case: fully reconciled, no further investment

The growth case uses the same model and the same costs, with faster institutional adoption: 2 licences in Year 2, 7 by the end of Year 3, plus one NHS ICB contract from March 2029. It needs no investment beyond the £14,000 already agreed; revenue pays for the four full-time hires.

Growth case	Year 1 (FY27)	Year 2 (FY28)	Year 3 (FY29)
Total revenue	£569	£36,763	£149,301
Operating profit / (loss)	(£4,803)	£20,174	(£35,726)
Closing cash	£8,680	£36,712	£21,064
Headcount (year end)	1	1	6

	Year 1 (FY27)	Year 2 (FY28)	Year 3 (FY29)
Partner-university licences (year end)	0	2	7
Students covered by licences (year end)	0	20,000	71,000
Insights Starter subscriptions (year end)	2	8	15
Cumulative verified students (year end)	320	2,820	11,820
Premium subscribers (year end)	5	29	95
NHS ICB contracts (year end)	0	0	1

The growth-case operating loss in Year 3 is a deliberate investment in the team ahead of the licence revenue the team wins. It is paid for out of cash built up in Year 2, and cash stays positive in every month (lowest £823, Mar-27). By the final quarter of Year 3, the growth case is profitable month by month again, with the full team in place. Growth-case P&L, cash flow and staffing are at Appendix F.

11. Revenue and Cost of Sales Forecast

All figures are in GBP and exclude VAT. DEQUAD is not VAT-registered: base-case turnover stays below the £90,000 registration threshold. Year 1 = September 2026 to August 2027.

11.1 Customer acquisition (base case)

	Year 1 (FY27)	Year 2 (FY28)	Year 3 (FY29)
New verified student sign-ups in year	300	1,500	4,000
Cumulative verified students (year end)	320	1,820	5,820
Monthly active students (year end)	211	1,130	3,283
Premium subscribers (year end)	5	20	59
Premium subscribers (average in year)	3.7	15.5	49.4
Insights Starter subscriptions (year end)	2	6	11
Insights Starter subscriptions (average)	0.6	4.8	8.9
Partner-university licences (year end)	0	1	3
Students covered by partner licences (year end)	0	10,000	26,000

Key acquisition assumptions

- **Students.** New verified sign-ups of 300 / 1,500 / 4,000 a year, spread across the academic calendar (16% Sep, 14% Oct, 12% Jan, 13% Aug for pre-arrival, and lower in summer). Active students decline by 6% a month without new sign-ups. The opening beta cohort is 20 verified accounts.
- **Premium conversion.** Premium goes live from November 2026. Conversion is 2.5% / 3.5% / 4.5% of active students *who are not covered by a university licence* (licensed students get Premium features free through their university). Licence coverage is assumed to be 50% of active students in Year 2 and 60% in Year 3.
- **Insights Starter.** 2 subscriptions by the end of Year 1 (first in April 2027), 6 by the end of Year 2, 11 by the end of Year 3 (one cancellation assumed in Year 3).
- **Partner licences.** None in Year 1. Licence 1 (c.10,000 students, the anchor university after the pilot) from October 2027. Licence 2 (c.10,000 students) from September 2028. Licence 3 (c.6,000 students) from March 2029. All renew annually.

Quarterly customer and revenue profile

Quarter	New sign-ups	Verified students	Premium subs	Starter subs	Licences	Revenue
Y1 Q1 (Sep-26 – Nov-26)	120	140	3	0	0	£15
Y1 Q2 (Dec-26 – Feb-27)	75	215	4	0	0	£55
Y1 Q3 (Mar-27 – May-27)	48	263	5	1	0	£175
Y1 Q4 (Jun-27 – Aug-27)	57	320	5	2	0	£325
Y2 Q1 (Sep-27 – Nov-27)	600	920	13	4	1	£3,993
Y2 Q2 (Dec-27 – Feb-28)	375	1,295	17	5	1	£5,874
Y2 Q3 (Mar-28 – May-28)	240	1,535	18	6	1	£6,069
Y2 Q4 (Jun-28 – Aug-28)	285	1,820	20	6	1	£6,174
Y3 Q1 (Sep-28 – Nov-28)	1,600	3,420	44	8	2	£11,669
Y3 Q2 (Dec-28 – Feb-29)	1,000	4,420	53	8	2	£11,983
Y3 Q3 (Mar-29 – May-29)	640	5,060	55	10	3	£15,228
Y3 Q4 (Jun-29 – Aug-29)	760	5,820	59	11	3	£15,428

11.2 Revenue forecast

	Year 1 (FY27)	Year 2 (FY28)	Year 3 (FY29)	3-yr total
Partner-university licences (£2/student/yr)	–	£18,333	£46,000	£64,333
Insights Starter (£49.99/month)	£350	£2,849	£5,349	£8,548
DEQUAD Premium (£4.99/month)	£220	£928	£2,959	£4,107
NHS ICB contracts	–	–	–	–
Total revenue	**£569**	**£22,111**	**£54,308**	**£76,988**

Licence revenue is recognised evenly over each 12-month term, although cash arrives up front (Section 12). Premium revenue is shown gross; app-store and payment fees sit in cost of sales.

11.3 Cost of sales

	Year 1 (FY27)	Year 2 (FY28)	Year 3 (FY29)	3-yr total
Cloud hosting & database	£470	£722	£1,458	£2,651
AI inference (safeguarding triage, cohort analysis)	£259	£786	£1,769	£2,814
Email, push & SMS	£132	£196	£380	£708
Payment processing & app-store fees	£29	£147	£398	£573
University onboarding & pilot delivery	£300	£600	£1,200	£2,100
Customer-success tooling	–	£220	£600	£820
Total cost of sales	**£1,190**	**£2,671**	**£5,805**	**£9,665**
Gross profit	**(£620)**	**£19,440**	**£48,503**	**£67,323**
Gross margin	**n/a**	**87.9%**	**89.3%**	**87.4%**

Cost-of-sales drivers. Hosting: £35 a month plus £0.02 per registered student. AI inference: £20 a month plus £0.01 per active student, plus £40 a month per licensed institution for cohort analysis. Email, push and SMS: £10 a month plus £0.005 per registered student. Payment fees: a blended 10% on Premium (Stripe plus the App Store and Google Play 15% small-business rate), 1.9% on Starter, nil on licences paid by bank transfer. Onboarding: £600 per new licence (training, travel and materials) plus £300 for pilot delivery. Year 1 gross profit is negative because the minimum platform cost comes before revenue does.

12. Cash Flow Forecast

12.1 Annual cash flow (base case)

	Year 1 (FY27)	Year 2 (FY28)	Year 3 (FY29)	3-yr total
Opening cash	£3,000	£8,680	£18,526	£3,000
Receipts — Premium & Starter subscriptions	£569	£3,778	£8,308	£12,655
Receipts — licences & contracts (annual in advance)	–	£20,000	£52,000	£72,000
Total trading receipts	**£569**	**£23,778**	**£60,308**	**£84,655**
Equity investment received (friends & family; Nigerian company)	£11,000	–	–	£11,000
Cost of sales	(£1,190)	(£2,671)	(£5,805)	(£9,665)
Staff costs (salaries, NI, pension)	–	–	(£31,835)	(£31,835)
Marketing	(£1,500)	(£3,500)	(£6,000)	(£11,000)
Other overheads (software, insurance, professional, office, compliance, travel)	(£2,600)	(£6,861)	(£10,221)	(£19,682)
Capital expenditure	(£600)	(£900)	(£1,200)	(£2,700)
Corporation tax paid	–	–	(£543)	(£543)
Total payments	**(£5,890)**	**(£13,932)**	**(£55,604)**	**(£75,425)**
Net cash flow	**£5,680**	**£9,846**	**£4,704**	**£20,230**
Closing cash	**£8,680**	**£18,526**	**£23,230**	**£23,230**

Cash-timing assumptions. Licences are invoiced on signature, one month before each term starts, and paid on 30-day terms. Premium and Starter are collected monthly by card. Suppliers are paid in the month incurred, by card or direct debit. Insurance is paid in monthly instalments. Corporation tax is paid nine months and one day after each 31 August year end.

12.2 Monthly cash flow

Year 1 (FY27): Sep 2026 – Aug 2027

£	Sep-26	Oct-26	Nov-26	Dec-26	Jan-27	Feb-27	Mar-27	Apr-27	May-27	Jun-27	Jul-27	Aug-27	Total
Opening cash	£3,000	£2,572	£2,293	£2,057	£1,835	£1,272	£1,038	£823	£10,641	£9,945	£9,633	£9,294	
Equity investment	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	£11,000	–	–	–	–	£11,000
Trading receipts	**–**	**–**	**£15**	**£15**	**£20**	**£20**	**£25**	**£75**	**£75**	**£75**	**£125**	**£125**	**£569**
Cost of sales	(£67)	(£69)	(£71)	(£72)	(£373)	(£74)	(£75)	(£77)	(£77)	(£77)	(£78)	(£80)	(£1,190)
Staff	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
Marketing	(£75)	(£75)	(£45)	(£30)	(£75)	(£45)	(£30)	(£150)	(£150)	(£150)	(£225)	(£450)	(£1,500)
Other overheads	(£286)	(£135)	(£135)	(£135)	(£135)	(£135)	(£135)	(£430)	(£544)	(£160)	(£160)	(£210)	(£2,600)
Capex	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	(£600)	–	–	–	–	(£600)
Corp. tax	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
Net cash flow	**(£428)**	**(£279)**	**(£236)**	**(£222)**	**(£563)**	**(£234)**	**(£215)**	**£9,818**	**(£696)**	**(£312)**	**(£338)**	**(£615)**	**£5,680**
Closing cash	**£2,572**	**£2,293**	**£2,057**	**£1,835**	**£1,272**	**£1,038**	**£823**	**£10,641**	**£9,945**	**£9,633**	**£9,294**	**£8,680**	

Year 2 (FY28): Sep 2027 – Aug 2028

£	Sep-27	Oct-27	Nov-27	Dec-27	Jan-28	Feb-28	Mar-28	Apr-28	May-28	Jun-28	Jul-28	Aug-28	Total
Opening cash	£8,680	£7,339	£25,945	£25,345	£23,453	£22,784	£22,274	£21,835	£20,864	£20,192	£19,938	£19,678	
Equity investment	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
Trading receipts	**£190**	**£20,205**	**£265**	**£265**	**£275**	**£335**	**£340**	**£340**	**£390**	**£390**	**£385**	**£400**	**£23,778**
Cost of sales	(£90)	(£759)	(£166)	(£167)	(£174)	(£180)	(£184)	(£186)	(£188)	(£189)	(£190)	(£197)	(£2,671)
Staff	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
Marketing	(£560)	(£490)	(£350)	(£140)	(£420)	(£315)	(£245)	(£175)	(£140)	(£105)	(£105)	(£455)	(£3,500)
Other overheads	(£881)	(£350)	(£350)	(£950)	(£350)	(£350)	(£350)	(£950)	(£734)	(£350)	(£350)	(£900)	(£6,861)
Capex	–	–	–	(£900)	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	(£900)
Corp. tax	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
Net cash flow	**(£1,341)**	**£18,606**	**(£600)**	**(£1,892)**	**(£669)**	**(£510)**	**(£439)**	**(£971)**	**(£672)**	**(£254)**	**(£260)**	**(£1,152)**	**£9,846**
Closing cash	**£7,339**	**£25,945**	**£25,345**	**£23,453**	**£22,784**	**£22,274**	**£21,835**	**£20,864**	**£20,192**	**£19,938**	**£19,678**	**£18,526**	

Year 3 (FY29): Sep 2028 – Aug 2029

£	Sep-28	Oct-28	Nov-28	Dec-28	Jan-29	Feb-29	Mar-29	Apr-29	May-29	Jun-29	Jul-29	Aug-29	Total
Opening cash	£18,526	£33,432	£48,426	£44,920	£41,019	£37,449	£32,112	£40,186	£36,978	£33,488	£29,892	£26,880	
Equity investment	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
Trading receipts	**£20,505**	**£20,545**	**£619**	**£619**	**£699**	**£664**	**£12,724**	**£729**	**£774**	**£769**	**£814**	**£844**	**£60,308**
Cost of sales	(£886)	(£308)	(£324)	(£328)	(£348)	(£359)	(£1,029)	(£435)	(£439)	(£441)	(£444)	(£463)	(£5,805)
Staff	(£3,038)	(£2,618)	(£2,618)	(£2,618)	(£2,618)	(£2,618)	(£2,618)	(£2,618)	(£2,618)	(£2,618)	(£2,618)	(£2,618)	(£31,835)
Marketing	(£960)	(£840)	(£600)	(£240)	(£720)	(£540)	(£420)	(£300)	(£240)	(£180)	(£180)	(£780)	(£6,000)
Other overheads	(£715)	(£584)	(£584)	(£1,334)	(£584)	(£2,484)	(£584)	(£584)	(£968)	(£584)	(£584)	(£634)	(£10,221)
Capex	–	(£1,200)	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	(£1,200)
Corp. tax	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	(£543)	–	–	(£543)
Net cash flow	**£14,906**	**£14,995**	**(£3,507)**	**(£3,901)**	**(£3,570)**	**(£5,337)**	**£8,073**	**(£3,207)**	**(£3,490)**	**(£3,596)**	**(£3,011)**	**(£3,651)**	**£4,704**
Closing cash	**£33,432**	**£48,426**	**£44,920**	**£41,019**	**£37,449**	**£32,112**	**£40,186**	**£36,978**	**£33,488**	**£29,892**	**£26,880**	**£23,230**	

The tightest point is Mar-27 (£823), at the end of the pilot and just before the post-pilot investment arrives. Until then the business runs only on the founder's £3,000, with marketing held to a minimum and every institutional-sales cost deferred. From April 2027 the balance does not fall below about £7,000. If the letter of intent takes longer to sign, the founder will keep the business in this lean mode (about £300 a month) until it is signed.

12.3 Downside test: the pilot does not lead to a letter of intent

This is the plan's biggest single risk, because both the first licence **and** the £11,000 investment depend on it. If the pilot does not lead to a letter of intent, the founder moves the business into survival mode. Overheads stay at Year 1 levels and work stays remote. Marketing is cut to a tenth of the Year 1 budget

(organic and ambassador-led only). Costs that only matter for selling to universities (Cyber Essentials, trademark, equipment) are dropped, and there is no founder pay and no hiring.

DEQUAD then trades on Premium and Starter revenue alone (Year 3 revenue £12,744). The lowest cash balance is £112, and the company ends Year 3 with £8,570. It also stays free to approach other universities for a pilot. The failure of its main commercial assumption slows DEQUAD down but does not end it.

13. Profit & Loss Forecast (base case)

	Year 1 (FY27)	Year 2 (FY28)	Year 3 (FY29)	3-yr total
Revenue	**£569**	**£22,111**	**£54,308**	**£76,988**
Cost of sales	(£1,190)	(£2,671)	(£5,805)	(£9,665)
Gross profit	**(£620)**	**£19,440**	**£48,503**	**£67,323**
Salaries	–	–	(£30,500)	(£30,500)
Employer NI (after Employment Allowance)	–	–	–	–
Employer pension (3%)	–	–	(£915)	(£915)
Other staff costs (DBS, induction)	–	–	(£420)	(£420)
Advertising & marketing	(£1,500)	(£3,500)	(£6,000)	(£11,000)
Software & developer accounts	(£639)	(£1,159)	(£1,639)	(£3,437)
Insurance (PI, cyber, public & employers' liability)	(£600)	(£1,100)	(£1,750)	(£3,450)
Accountancy & bookkeeping	–	(£600)	(£1,230)	(£1,830)
Legal & IP protection (contracts, patent search, UK patent filing)	–	(£1,500)	(£1,900)	(£3,400)
Office / co-working	(£125)	(£600)	(£1,200)	(£1,925)
Compliance (ICO, Cyber Essentials, IP, filings)	(£756)	(£486)	(£486)	(£1,728)
Travel & campus visits	(£360)	(£1,200)	(£1,800)	(£3,360)
Bank, telephone & internet	(£120)	(£216)	(£216)	(£552)
Total overheads	**(£4,100)**	**(£10,361)**	**(£48,056)**	**(£62,517)**
EBITDA	**(£4,720)**	**£9,079**	**£447**	**£4,806**
Depreciation	(£83)	(£425)	(£867)	(£1,375)
Operating profit / (loss)	**(£4,803)**	**£8,654**	**(£420)**	**£3,431**
Corporation tax (19%, after losses b/f and 100% AIA)	–	(£543)	–	(£543)
Profit / (loss) after tax	**(£4,803)**	**£8,111**	**(£420)**	**£2,888**
Net margin	n/a	36.7%	-0.8%	

Corporation tax computation

	Operating result	Add back depreciation	Less AIA	Tax-adjusted result	Losses c/f	CT @19%	Paid
Year 1	(£4,803)	£83	(£600)	(£5,320)	£5,320	–	Jun-28
Year 2	£8,654	£425	(£900)	£8,179	–	£543	Jun-29
Year 3	(£420)	£867	(£1,200)	(£753)	£753	–	Jun-30 (after forecast)

Year 1's loss is carried forward against Year 2 profits. Equipment qualifies for the 100% Annual Investment Allowance. Profits are below £50,000, so the 19% small profits rate applies.

Commentary. Year 1 is a deliberate investment year, with a loss of (£4,803) funded from the equity raised. Year 2 turns profitable (£8,111 after tax) on the first licence and a cost base still carried by an unpaid founder. In Year 3 the company starts paying the founder, makes its first two part-time hires and invests in a UK patent application, and still roughly breaks even, with an after-tax result of (£420). Profit is not the aim in the early years; showing that the company can pay for its own team from revenue is.

14. Balance Sheet Forecast (base case)

At 31 August	2027 (Y1)	2028 (Y2)	2029 (Y3)
Fixed assets at cost	£600	£1,500	£2,700
Less accumulated depreciation	(£83)	(£508)	(£1,375)
Net book value of fixed assets	**£517**	**£992**	**£1,325**
Stock	–	–	–
Trade debtors (licence invoices, 30-day terms)	–	£20,000	£20,000
Cash at bank	£8,680	£18,526	£23,230
Total assets	**£9,197**	**£39,517**	**£44,555**
Deferred income (licence fees invoiced in advance)	–	(£21,667)	(£27,667)
Corporation tax payable	–	(£543)	–
Total liabilities	**–**	**(£22,210)**	**(£27,667)**
Net assets	**£9,197**	**£17,308**	**£16,888**
Share capital & share premium (founder £3k; friends & family £3k; Nigerian company £8k)	£14,000	£14,000	£14,000
Profit & loss reserve	(£4,803)	£3,308	£2,888
Total shareholders' funds	**£9,197**	**£17,308**	**£16,888**

The balance sheet is generated by the same model as the P&L and cash flow, and balances in every year. **Deferred income** is licence fees invoiced in advance but not yet earned. This is a sign of healthy, up-front payment terms, not debt. There are no borrowings. Shareholders' funds include the £14,000 of equity invested by the founder, friends and family, and the Nigerian company investor. The split between nominal share capital and share premium depends on the share price agreed for each allotment.

15. Forecasted Stock Levels

DEQUAD is a software business and **holds no stock**. Promotional materials for freshers' events are bought for immediate use and expensed as marketing.

	Y1	Y2	Y3
Opening stock	–	–	–
Purchases	–	–	–
Closing stock	–	–	–

16. Forecasted Advertising and Marketing Expenditure

Channel	Year 1 (FY27)	Year 2 (FY28)	Year 3 (FY29)	3-yr total
Student ambassador programme (incentives, referral rewards)	£500	£900	£1,500	£2,900
Freshers' / Welcome Week stands & printed materials	£400	£700	£1,000	£2,100
Instagram & TikTok (organic content + boosted posts)	£300	£700	£1,200	£2,200
Google Search ads (brand + 'student friends' terms)	–	£300	£600	£900
Content, SEO & safeguarding white paper	£100	£300	£500	£900
B2B events & PR (AMOSSHE, UUK, Wonkhe, NatWest network)	£200	£600	£1,200	£2,000
Total advertising & marketing	**£1,500**	**£3,500**	**£6,000**	**£11,000**
Marketing as % of revenue	n/a	15.8%	11.0%	
Blended cost per verified student sign-up	£5.00	£2.33	£1.50	

Spend by quarter. Spend is weighted to the academic calendar, peaking at freshers' season.

	Q1 Sep–Nov	Q2 Dec–Feb	Q3 Mar–May	Q4 Jun–Aug	Total
Year 1	£195	£150	£330	£825	£1,500
Year 2	£1,400	£875	£560	£665	£3,500
Year 3	£2,400	£1,500	£960	£1,140	£6,000

Institutional sales are led by the founder and cost very little in cash. Event attendance and sector PR are the main paid B2B items. Paid search and boosted social posts only start in Year 2, when cost per sign-up can be measured against Premium conversion. In the growth case, marketing is 1.5× the base in Year 2 and 2× the base in Year 3 (Appendix F).

17. Forecasted Fixed Asset Schedule

DEQUAD's main asset, the software platform, was built by the founder and the wider team and is not capitalised. Development costs are expensed, which is prudent and simplifies R&D tax-relief claims. Tangible assets are limited to IT equipment, depreciated straight-line over 3 years from the month of purchase.

Asset	Acquired	Cost	Dep'n Y1	Dep'n Y2	Dep'n Y3	NBV at Y3 end
QA test handsets (1 x iOS, 1 x Android, refurbished)	Apr-27	£600	£83	£200	£200	£117
Development laptop (engineering)	Dec-27	£900	–	£225	£300	£375
Laptop — Safeguarding & Trust Lead	Oct-28	£850	–	–	£260	£590
Campus event kit (banner, display)	Oct-28	£350	–	–	£107	£243
Total		**£2,700**	**£83**	**£425**	**£867**	**£1,325**

Net book value movement

	Opening NBV	Additions	Depreciation	Closing NBV
Year 1	–	£600	(£83)	£517
Year 2	£517	£900	(£425)	£992
Year 3	£992	£1,200	(£867)	£1,325

The founder and wider team use their own existing laptops in Year 1. Test devices are bought only after the post-pilot investment arrives (April 2027).

18. Forecasted Staff Costs

18.1 Roles and pay (base case)

Role	Paid from	FTE	Y1 salary	Y2 salary	Y3 salary	Y3 employer NI (gross)	Y3 pension 3%
Founder & CEO — Yusuf Quadri	Sep-28	1.00	–	–	£10,000	£750	£300
Software Engineer (part-time, 0.5 FTE)	Sep-28	0.50	–	–	£12,500	£1,125	£375
Safeguarding & Trust Lead (part-time, c.10 hrs/wk)	Sep-28	0.25	–	–	£8,000	£450	£240

18.2 Total staff costs (base case)

	Year 1 (FY27)	Year 2 (FY28)	Year 3 (FY29)	3-yr total
Gross salaries	–	–	£30,500	£30,500
Employer NI before allowance (15% above £5,000)	–	–	£2,325	£2,325
Less Employment Allowance	–	–	(£2,325)	(£2,325)
Employer pension (3% of salary)	–	–	£915	£915
Other staff costs (enhanced DBS, induction & safeguarding training)	–	–	£420	£420
Total staff cost	**–**	**–**	**£31,835**	**£31,835**
Headcount at year end (incl. founder)	1	1	3	
FTE at year end	1.00	1.00	1.75	

Basis of calculation

- **Employer National Insurance:** 15% on earnings above the £5,000 secondary threshold (2025/26 rates). DEQUAD qualifies for the **£10,500 Employment Allowance** because a non-director employee is on the payroll, so no employer NI is payable in the base case.
- **Pension:** DEQUAD pays a 3% employer contribution on **all** salaries, even where earnings are below the £10,000 auto-enrolment trigger. This is a deliberate fair-employer policy.
- **Other staff costs:** enhanced DBS check and safeguarding induction for each new employee. Employers' liability insurance is in the insurance line.
- **Founder:** paid as a director through PAYE from Year 3. Before then, unpaid (Section 7.1).

18.3 Growth-case staffing

Role (growth case)	Paid from	FTE	Annual salary
Founder & CEO — Yusuf Quadri	Sep-28	1.00	£24,000
Software Engineer (full-time)	Sep-28	1.00	£30,000
Safeguarding & Trust Lead (part-time)	Sep-28	0.25	£8,000
Sales Lead (full-time)	Sep-28	1.00	£25,000
Support Agent (full-time)	Oct-28	1.00	£25,000
Student Ambassador (full-time)	Oct-28	1.00	£25,000

	Year 1 (FY27)	Year 2 (FY28)	Year 3 (FY29)	3-yr total
Gross salaries	–	–	£132,833	£132,833
Employer NI (after Employment Allowance)	–	–	£5,050	£5,050
Employer pension (3%)	–	–	£3,985	£3,985
Total staff cost	**–**	**–**	**£142,918**	**£142,918**
Headcount at year end	1	1	6	

The Sales Lead, Support Agent and Student Ambassador roles are each paid **£25,000 a year** and the Software Engineer **£30,000**; and the plan funds them for at least 12 months from licence revenue.

19. Appendices

Ref	Document	File
A	Founder academic certificates — Yusuf Quadri	`A_founder_academic_certificates.pdf`
B	**CV — Yusuf Quadri, Founder & CEO**	`B_founder_cv.pdf`
C	Personal commitment and undertaking	`C_personal_commitment_undertaking.pdf`
D	Wellbeing baseline and pilot evaluation methodology	`D_wellbeing_baseline_methodology.pdf`
E	Data Protection Impact Assessment	`E_dpia.pdf`
F	Financial model — 36-month workings, base and growth cases	`DEQUAD_Financial_Model_v6.xlsx` and Appendix F below
G	Job descriptions	`G_job_descriptions.pdf`
H	University letter of interest template	`H_university_letter_of_interest_template.pdf`
I	Online Safety Act 2023 compliance statement	`I_online_safety_act_compliance.pdf`
J	Architecture diagram	`J_architecture_diagram.pdf`
K	Product screenshots	`K_product_screenshots.pdf`
L	Risk register	`DEQUAD_Risk_Register.pdf`
N	**CVs — Dr Gerald Marfo, Adedapo Ajuwon, Chinyere Jennifer**	`N_wider_team_cvs.pdf`
O	Safeguarding and clinical-awareness certifications — Yusuf Quadri	`O_safeguarding_certifications.pdf`

19.1 Founder CV summary

Yusuf Quadri — Founder & CEO. Recovery Coordinator, Change Grow Live (2025–present): complex caseloads, safeguarding referrals, dynamic risk assessment, multi-agency coordination with clinicians, probation, housing and social care, and volunteer supervision. Clinical Support Worker, East London NHS Foundation Trust (2022–present): care for adults with mental-health conditions, learning disabilities and autism; escalating safeguarding concerns. President, University of Bedfordshire Students' Union (2021–2023, two terms): represented 10,000+ students and oversaw a £900,000 budget. Earlier B2B business development (UGC Planet, Mavin Care). MBA with Data Analytics (2024); MSc International Relations Management (2020); BSc International Relations & Diplomacy (2017). Full CV: Appendix B.

Appendix F — Financial Model Summary

All financial tables in Sections 11–18 come from a single 36-month model (`build_business_plan_v6.py`; workbook `DEQUAD_Financial_Model_v6.xlsx`). The model checks that the balance sheet balances in every year.

F.1 Key assumptions

Area	Assumption
Funding	£14,000 equity: founder £3,000 (Sep 2026); friends & family £3,000 and Nigerian company £8,000, both conditional on a successful pilot and signed LOI (modelled Apr 2027); no loans, grants or R&D tax credits
Prices	Premium £4.99/month; Insights Starter £49.99/month; Licence £2.00/enrolled student/year
Billing	Licences invoiced annually, one month before each term, on 30-day terms; revenue recognised monthly
In-kind support	NatWest Accelerator office space, legal and accountancy support until March 2027
Corporation tax	19% small profits rate; losses carried forward; 100% AIA on equipment; paid 9 months + 1 day after year end
Employer NI	15% above £5,000 per employee; £10,500 Employment Allowance
Pension	3% employer contribution on all salaries
VAT	Not registered; base-case turnover below £90,000
Depreciation	IT equipment, straight-line over 36 months

F.2 Growth case — Profit & Loss

	Year 1 (FY27)	Year 2 (FY28)	Year 3 (FY29)	3-yr total
Revenue	**£569**	**£36,763**	**£149,301**	**£186,634**
Cost of sales	(£1,190)	(£4,053)	(£12,881)	(£18,124)
Gross profit	**(£620)**	**£32,710**	**£136,420**	**£168,510**
Salaries	–	–	(£132,833)	(£132,833)
Employer NI (after Employment Allowance)	–	–	(£5,050)	(£5,050)
Employer pension (3%)	–	–	(£3,985)	(£3,985)
Other staff costs (DBS, induction)	–	–	(£1,050)	(£1,050)
Advertising & marketing	(£1,500)	(£5,250)	(£12,000)	(£18,750)
Software & developer accounts	(£639)	(£1,159)	(£1,639)	(£3,437)
Insurance (PI, cyber, public & employers' liability)	(£600)	(£1,100)	(£2,350)	(£4,050)
Accountancy & bookkeeping	–	(£600)	(£1,710)	(£2,310)
Legal & IP protection (contracts, patent search, UK patent filing)	–	(£1,500)	(£1,900)	(£3,400)
Office / co-working	(£125)	(£600)	(£3,600)	(£4,325)
Compliance (ICO, Cyber Essentials, IP, filings)	(£756)	(£486)	(£486)	(£1,728)
Travel & campus visits	(£360)	(£1,200)	(£3,600)	(£5,160)
Bank, telephone & internet	(£120)	(£216)	(£216)	(£552)
Total overheads	**(£4,100)**	**(£12,111)**	**(£170,419)**	**(£186,630)**
EBITDA	**(£4,720)**	**£20,599**	**(£34,000)**	**(£18,121)**
Depreciation	(£83)	(£425)	(£1,726)	(£2,235)
Operating profit / (loss)	**(£4,803)**	**£20,174**	**(£35,726)**	**(£20,355)**
Corporation tax (19%, after losses b/f and 100% AIA)	–	(£2,732)	–	(£2,732)
Profit / (loss) after tax	**(£4,803)**	**£17,442**	**(£35,726)**	**(£23,087)**
Net margin	n/a	47.4%	-23.9%	

F.3 Growth case — Cash flow

	Year 1 (FY27)	Year 2 (FY28)	Year 3 (FY29)	3-yr total
Opening cash	£3,000	£8,680	£36,712	£3,000
Receipts — Premium & Starter subscriptions	£569	£5,097	£12,134	£17,800
Receipts — licences & contracts (annual in advance)	–	£40,000	£162,000	£202,000
Total trading receipts	**£569**	**£45,097**	**£174,134**	**£219,800**
Equity investment received (friends & family; Nigerian company)	£11,000	–	–	£11,000
Cost of sales	(£1,190)	(£4,053)	(£12,881)	(£18,124)
Staff costs (salaries, NI, pension)	–	–	(£142,918)	(£142,918)
Marketing	(£1,500)	(£5,250)	(£12,000)	(£18,750)
Other overheads (software, insurance, professional, office, compliance, travel)	(£2,600)	(£6,861)	(£15,501)	(£24,962)
Capital expenditure	(£600)	(£900)	(£3,750)	(£5,250)
Corporation tax paid	–	–	(£2,732)	(£2,732)
Total payments	**(£5,890)**	**(£17,064)**	**(£189,783)**	**(£212,736)**
Net cash flow	**£5,680**	**£28,033**	**(£15,648)**	**£18,064**
Closing cash	**£8,680**	**£36,712**	**£21,064**	**£21,064**

In the growth case, turnover would pass the £90,000 VAT registration threshold during Year 3. Universities cannot usually recover VAT, so DEQUAD would review licence pricing at that point. The growth-case figures are shown net of VAT.

All figures are forecasts, not guarantees. This business plan was prepared by Yusuf Quadri (Founder & CEO) for the UK Innovator Founder endorsement application to UKES. Version 6.0, October 2026.